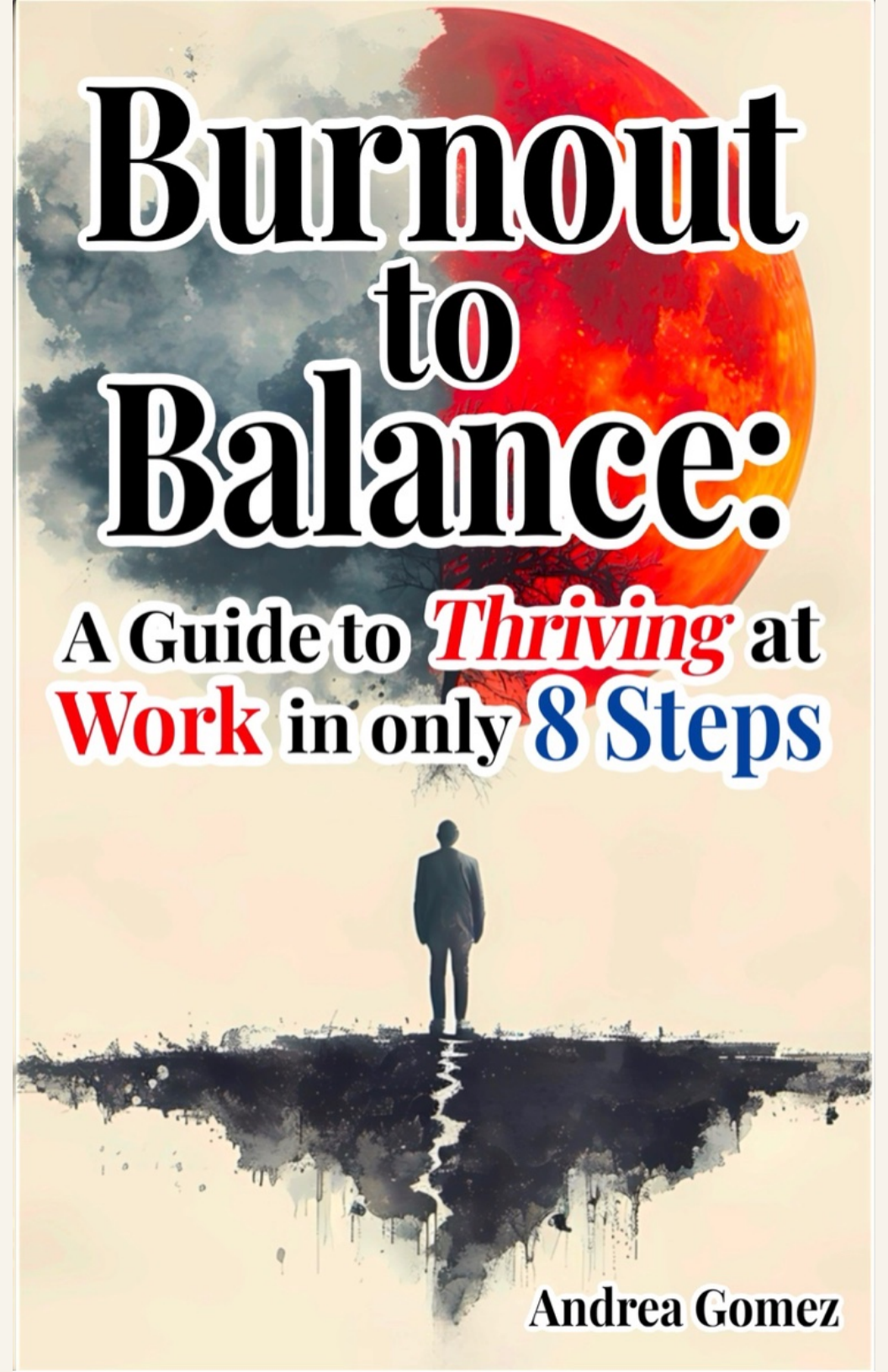


The background of the cover features a large, vibrant red sun or moon in the upper right, partially obscured by dark, swirling clouds. In the lower center, a silhouette of a person stands on a dark, horizontal, brush-stroke-like base. Below this base, there are dark, vertical, paint-drip-like marks extending downwards. The overall color palette is dominated by the red of the sun, the dark greys of the clouds and base, and the light beige of the background.

Burnout to Balance:

A Guide to *Thriving* at
Work in only **8 Steps**

Andrea Gomez

Chapter 1: Face Your Stress and Its Impact

Step 1: Recognize Burnout for What It Is

Job burnout is work-related stress that leaves you physically and emotionally drained. It can make you feel useless, powerless, or detached from your job. You might second-guess your abilities, struggle to focus, or feel like your work has no real value.

Burnout is not classified as a medical condition, but it is a real problem that can lead to anxiety, depression, and even physical health issues. Some people experience it as extreme fatigue. Others feel stuck in a cycle of frustration and apathy, unable to find motivation no matter how hard they try.

Research in neuroscience and psychology, including several studies published in journals like *Biological Psychiatry* and *Nature Reviews Neuroscience* revealed that burnout physically alters the brain. Long-term exposure to workplace stress impacts three main brain areas:

Prefrontal Cortex Shrinkage: The prefrontal cortex, responsible for decision-making, focus, and impulse control, shrinks under chronic stress. This is why burned-out individuals struggle with concentration, problem-solving, and even basic decision-making. Tasks that once felt easy now feel like too much effort.

Amygdala Enlargement: The amygdala, the brain's emotional response center, becomes hyperactive when stress is constant. This means heightened anxiety, increased irritability, and an overactive

fight-or-flight response. Small work stressors, like an email from your boss, suddenly feel like full-blown threats.

Hippocampus Damage: The hippocampus, which regulates memory and learning, also takes a hit. Burnout can lead to forgetfulness, difficulty retaining information, and an overall sense of brain fog. Ever found yourself rereading the same email five times and still not processing it? That's your hippocampus waving a white flag.

The longer burnout persists, the more these changes reinforce each other. Your brain becomes wired to anticipate stress, making relaxation and recovery even harder. But the good news is these effects aren't permanent. When stress levels decrease, the brain has the ability to rebuild and restore itself.

The interesting thing is that two people can face the same work conditions, but only one burns out. Factors like personality, past job experiences, and workplace culture all play a role in how burnout takes hold.

Are You Burned Out? Ask Yourself These Questions

IF ANY OF THESE SOUND familiar, burnout might be at play:

- Do you struggle to start your workday and feel like you are forcing yourself to keep going?
- Have you started questioning whether your job has any value or meaning?
- Do you feel detached from your work, coworkers, or clients?
- Have you lost patience with the people you work with, or even dislike them?

- Do you lack energy and feel mentally foggy or unproductive?
- Does your work feel pointless, even when you are meeting expectations?
- Have you started doubting your skills and abilities?
- Are you relying on food, alcohol, or other distractions to cope?
- Have your sleep habits changed, or are you experiencing physical symptoms like headaches or stomach issues?

If you are nodding along to even one or two of these, you're at your limit. The key thing to remember is that this is not just "being stressed." It is a sign that your work situation is affecting your well-being in ways that cannot be fixed by pushing through.

Why Do Some People Burn Out Faster Than Others?

Getting things done should be simple. You make a list, tackle each task, and move on. But modern life has a way of making even the most basic responsibilities feel tiring. There is always something demanding your attention, and no matter how much you accomplish, there is always more waiting. The problem is not just the workload. It is the expectation that you should always be able to handle it.

That expectation is exactly what leads to burnout. You keep pushing, pretending your energy is limitless, until one day you hit a wall. You fall behind on tasks or feel that you have a never-ending to-do list. If you take an honest look at it, the exhaustion runs deeper. It is not just about your everyday stress. It is about how you have been conditioned to work.

Your Inner Child and Burnout: What You Were Taught About Work

A lot of people don't realize that their relationship with work was shaped long before they ever had a job.

For those raised on the idea that success comes from relentless effort, overworking feels less like a choice and more like gravity. The pressure starts early. School drills in the idea that productivity equals worth. The fear of not landing a job keeps you grinding harder than necessary. Once you have a job, the fear of losing it keeps you pushing further. Eventually, work and self-worth blur together until one is impossible to untangle from the other.

That's why burnout does not feel like a temporary setback. It feels like anxiety, depression, anger, and personal failure. But this is where the shift needs to happen. Burnout is not proof you are not working hard enough. It is proof you were never meant to work like this in the first place.

The real culprit is the silent beliefs running in the background, whispering that slowing down is the same as giving up. This is why a vacation or a mental health day will not fix it. You have to go straight to the source, the beliefs that got you here in the first place.

And that brings us to your inner child, the part of you that absorbed all those early lessons about what it means to be "good enough." If your worth was tied to productivity, if you were praised for being helpful but made to feel guilty for resting, those lessons did not vanish when you grew up. They just found new ways to push you toward overwork, toward people-pleasing, toward defining yourself by how much you can do for others.

For some, burnout does not show up as exhaustion. It arrives as numbness, as detachment. Instead of proving their worth through

work, they disengage completely. The belief system shifts, not to overcompensation, but to indifference. Yet, even this is often rooted in the same childhood messages. If constant effort only led to exhaustion or disappointment, the inner child might decide it is safer to check out entirely.

Different reactions, same core issue. Whether it looks like working yourself into the ground or not showing up at all, burnout often traces back to those early, unspoken lessons about self-worth. And until those lessons get rewritten, the cycle does not stop.

Flushing Out the Stress at Work

Now that you know what burnout looks like, let's try to address the stressors that are adding to it and how to quickly clear out the yucky feelings while at work.

You have to flush the stressors out. You have to move, breathe, laugh, or create. Anything that tells your nervous system the crisis is over and it can stop bracing for impact. Movement is the fastest way to clear stress because your body is built to deal with threats through action. You don't need to run five miles or lift heavy weights, just move. Walk around the block, stretch, shake out your arms and legs. Anything that gets your blood flowing helps your body reset. If that feels like too much, start with breathing. When stress kicks in, your breath gets shallow and fast, making everything feel worse. Slow it down. Try box breathing. Inhale for five, hold for five, exhale for ten, pause for five. Do it three times and feel the shift.

If breathing isn't cutting it, laugh. Not a polite chuckle. Not the fake kind you do when your boss makes a bad joke. Real, gut-wrenching, tear-streaming laughter. The kind that hijacks your whole body and leaves you gasping for air. Cats doing cat things on Instagram, it is!

Laughter is a biological reset, built into us long before emails and performance evaluations turned everything into a grind. And if you can't laugh, make something. Write, paint, build something with your hands. Creativity gives stress a place to go. It doesn't have to be good, and no one has to see it. Just do something that isn't about work or getting the next task done.

Did you know that humming, singing, or even gently gargling water stimulates the vagus nerve, which soothes stress responses? Why do you think there are so many people you've met at work humming while working? It only takes a minute or two and settles racing thoughts.

Then there's the cold water reset. Splash cold water on your face or drink a glass of ice water. The jolt can shift your body out of a stressed state and slow down a racing heart.

With practice, you'll start to notice how different stress levels feel in your body. You'll know which days require more or less time, more or less effort, and what actually works for you.

Flushing Out the Stress Away from Work

One way to keep workplace stress from tailing you home is to create small end-of-day rituals. Think of them as mental "bookends" that nudge your brain out of work mode and into something that resembles an actual life. Start with a firm clock-out routine. Close your laptop. Shut down the apps on your mobile phone that never stop giving you alerts. Toss your work phone in a drawer like it personally offended you. Doing the same small thing every day tells your brain, That's it. We're done here.

Your commute can also serve as a transition. Ditch the news and crime podcasts that leave you wondering if they solved the murder, and swap them for music that lifts your mood. Or sit in silence for a minute, just you and your thoughts. No notifications trying to rope you back in. If

your commute is short, spend 60 seconds in your car or at the doorway, breathing like someone who actually wants to unwind.

Moving your body is another way to shift out of work mode. Take a walk, stretch a little, or do a quick workout. No need to go for a personal best. Just do a little exercise to break free from the tension that's been hitching a ride on your shoulders all day.

Hobbies work wonders too. Read a chapter of a book that has nothing to do with your job. Pick up a guitar and play a few messy chords. Do some crocheting or knitting, or color in your adult coloring book.

Journaling or brain-dumping can also clear your mind. Scribble down any lingering tasks, worries, or reminders in a notebook. This takes them off your mental “open tabs” and keeps them on paper instead of taking up valuable mental space.

Connecting with others is another way to separate from work. Text a friend who makes you laugh. Call someone just to talk about a ridiculous TV show. A conversation about literally anything other than work is a good thing.

Setting a digital curfew helps reinforce the boundary between work and personal time. Set a daily cutoff for checking work messages and let teammates know you'll be offline at a certain time, barring emergencies. Your brain needs to know when it's allowed to stop being on high alert.

And then there's sleep, the final frontier. A bedtime routine that doesn't involve doom-scrolling is your best bet. Dim the lights, read something that won't raise your blood pressure, or do some relaxation exercises so your brain doesn't start replaying the day's disasters at 2 a.m.

Putting some or all of these ideas into practice can stop the workday from creeping into your downtime. The trick is doing them consistently

until your brain understands that work is done and you're allowed to enjoy the rest of your life.

Next chapter: Understanding the root of your stress (are you too warm to be respected, or too respected to be liked?)

KEEP READING

Want the other 7 steps?

Get the full book on Amazon:

Amazon.com (USA)

Amazon.ca (Canada)

burnouttobalanceguide.com

Instagram: @msjag_writer